

SHIFTING LOYALTIES CM Mohan Yadav and state BJP chief V.D. Sharma welcome Congress MLA Kamlesh Shah in Bhopal

Lok Sabha constituency, the lone seat the Congress won in 2019 and represented by Kamal Nath's son Nakul, is a prestige battle between the BJP and the Congress. Before Shah's defection, the Congress held all the seven assembly segments that are part of the Lok Sabha seat. Sources say the defections fit right into the BJP's plan to wrest the seat from the Congress.

BJP sources paint the phenomenon of Congressmen shifting loyalties as a near-tsunami. "In the last two and a half months, over 18,000 Congressmen have joined the BJP, including three former MPs, 13 former MLAs, two mayors, a total of 300 corporators, sarpanches and other elected leaders," claims Mishra. The Congress, naturally, contests the figures, but is clearly discomfited.

While it seems most Congressmen are welcome in the BJP, for some, clearance from the central leadership is sought. In early March, former Union minister Suresh Pachouri joined the BJP along with several former MLAs, including Sanjay Shukla from Indore who had three months ago contested the assembly election against senior BJP leader and state minister Kailash Vijayvargiya.

BJP strategists say they have a team that proactively seeks out Congress leaders wanting to join them. While this may be true for Chhindwara, it may not apply to other parts of the state. In Chhindwara, Kamal Nath has over the years built up a strong booth-level infantry; the BJP sees benefits in head-hunting at this level. "In most cases, Congress leaders who are moving out are doing so out of their own calculations. Some are being probed by the state or central agencies while others believe they may get a better deal in the BJP," says a BJP leader.

Many within the BJP have not been totally on board with the strategy. Vijayvargiya spoke out against the possibility of Kamal Nath joining the BJP. Later, he said he stalled the entry of some Congress leaders in Indore owing to opposition by MLA Usha Thakur. BJP sources say the number of people who have been denied permission to join is much more than those who have joined in the past three months.

Why is the state Congress unit, led by Jitu Patwari, unable to stanch this bleeding? "The party has long been divided into factions led by different leaders, who occasionally unite based on shared interests. With Patwari's appointment, there are leaders who feel their interests are at risk," says a Congress functionary. "The Congress has always worked on a concept of 'guardianship', and workers and leaders are feeling the absence of a guardian—both in Delhi and Bhopal. There is no one they can go to, in case of a grievance. This is causing many of them to leave," says political analyst Girija Shankar. Many are echoing that in a thinning party. ■



2022, buzz went around that Thakor was asked to withdraw. Shobhana, a school teacher, was not even a primary member of the BJP till days before her candidature was announced. Similarly, in Surendranagar, rebellion is mounting against candidate Chandubhai Sehora, who had joined the BJP from the Congress in 2017.

In Vadodara, however, the protest was over the non-performance of sitting MP Ranjanben Bhatt, which led her to pull out of the poll race. The dissenters claimed the "VIP seat had been ignored" during her two terms. "When homegrown leaders are being replaced, why is she being repeated a third time from a safe seat?" asked a BJP functionary. Prime Minister Narendra Modi had contested from Vadodara and Varanasi simultaneously in 2014 and later vacated the former.

The ongoing burst of unrest began after the December 2022 assembly election, during which five Congress MLAs and one AAP MLA crossed over to the BJP. Cadre morale took a blow when four of the five candidates chosen for the upcoming assembly bypolls on May 7, to be held with the one-phase Lok Sabha election, turned out to be former Congress members.

But it was in Amreli constituency that all hell broke loose: when sitting MP Naran Kachhadiya was replaced with Bharat Sutariya, the district panchayat president, the mutual antagonism between the two factions erupted into full-blown violence.

In Valsad (ST) too, party workers are up against Dhaval Patel's candidature—the argument here is that he is an outsider. Dhaval, from the neighbouring Navsari district, previously served as the national social media in-charge of the party's Tribal Morcha. A similar rebellion among workers is evident in the Junagadh and Morbi seats, as observed through social media posts and posters.

The only alternative for the dissenters, if their demands are not met, is to remain passive during the election. But the party is adopting patchwork solutions to pacify them for the time being. ■